

Dear Zillow Hiring Team,

I am writing to express my interest in the Senior Data Scientist role at Zillow, which was referred to me by Stephanie Almeida. As a homeowner and someone who is interested in real estate as a hobby, Zillow has always appealed to me as a place to work. I enjoy consuming house tour content and house renovation content online while also completing projects around my own house. The Zillow app has many features for searching and looking at available homes which I've had fun using even when I'm not house shopping. In particular, the "Zestimate" feature brings a lot of value by giving the user a quick and accurate estimate for a home's value. As a professional data scientist, getting to delve into housing data to extract insight would be a perfect fit. Because of my interest and my strong background in computer vision, I would be able to offer a valuable perspective on your team.

Over the past eight years at Corning, I have honed my expertise as a data scientist in the computer vision space. I am now eager to apply my experience designing complex, automated systems to the dynamic world of real estate. I bring a proven track record of driving data solutions end-to-end—from initial conception through validation and production deployment. In my current role at Corning I have exemplified this by helping to define new image analysis problems, developing a solution, patenting it, and then delivering the solution to production. The most potent example of this is a patent-pending solution for background correcting some optical aberrations. This background correction technique has enabled the next generation of cover glass for all main brands of smartphone.

Beyond technical execution, I excel at translating complex problems for understanding and communicating practical expectations to stakeholders. In my current role I take complicated technical models and communicate them not only to my senior management but also to our customers. I teach methods with a goal of intuitive understanding and communicate results so they can be interpreted by anyone. Most recently this has been explaining to our customer how we as a metrology team arrive at spec limits for manufacturing.

In my daily work I have learned to optimize my productivity using AI agents and tools. I not only stay up to date, but I actually enjoy learning new and different tools as they are released. My current work setup is Claude Code + VS Code while at home I use Cursor.

Thank you for considering my application and I would welcome the opportunity to learn more about the role.

Sincerely,

Mike Schmidlin

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Summary

Data Scientist (MS) with 8+ years of experience and expertise in computer vision, data analysis, and machine learning. Proven ability to lead projects, effectively communicate technical subjects to stake holders, and collaborate with cross-functional teams to deliver impactful results.

Work Experience

Corning Incorporated

Corning, NY

Staff Data Scientist

2026 – Current

Developed machine learning solutions for measurement and process applications in order to improve business capability.

- Increased image segmentation capability by creating an ML-Ops pipeline for prism coupled spectroscopy data. Built a React dashboard front end along with data systems (MongoDB and S3) for managing raw images and labels.
- Mentored across career levels (interns, technicians, and junior engineers) in statistical analysis, software, and presenting results, building independent team capability.

Sr. Data Scientist

2022 – 2026

Led data science initiatives to improve characterizations of chemically strengthened glass used in mobile devices which enabled quality control of the manufacturing process.

- Invented a new algorithm (patent pending) to localize new types of features in an image using a moving window Fourier Transform.
- Removed a production blocking issue for the next generation of glass-ceramic phone glass by using image normalization to correct for optical aberrations in the background of the image (patent pending).
- Decreased production loss by enhancing an existing image processing algorithm with a classification neural network. The classification model improved feature detection in edge case scenarios by 90%.
- Reduced risk for customer in the measurement system by developing a software framework to validate measurement images in live camera view. The image processing runs asynchronously at 20fps while annotating image features which creates a smooth user experience.
- Expanded acceptable range of glass stress by $\sim 20\%$ without increasing risk to customer by modeling glass fragility (brittleness) with Logistic Regression in order to more accurately determine the USL (Upper Spec Limit). The model was deployed to a streamlit web app for use with future glass recipes.
- Enabled 5 years of consistent software releases by automating Gauge Repeatability and Reproducibility (GRR) analysis in a streamlit web app for use by our software QA (Quality Assurance) team.

Measurement Engineer

2018 – 2022

Accelerated development of glass vial measurement systems to high volume manufacturing as part of \$204M government program Operation Warp Speed.

- Performed and automated data analysis on production data using python scripts and SQL queries to determine effectiveness of inline measurement systems.
- Quantified repeatability of measurement systems through GRR and Analysis of Variance across a wide range of glass attributes such as stress, thickness, warp, and defect sizing.

Education

Data Science Master's Degree

2023

University of Denver, Daniel Felix Ritchie School of Engineering & Computer Science

Remote

Math & Music Bachelor's Degree

2018

State University of New York at Potsdam

Potsdam, NY

Additional Projects

TrendLine | Python, alpaca, Ollama

2026

Engineered an automated stock trading program which uses financial news data to determine market sentiment and trade stocks.

Slide Quest | Python, pygame

2024-2025

Developed a top down puzzle game in python for PC. Key features: seeded map generation, breadth first search level solver, custom level editor, dependency injection and IOC.

Technical Skills

Programming Languages: Python, C#, React, SQL

Tech Tools: Cursor, Claude Code, VS Code, Visual Studio, .Net, WPF, Git, S3, Machine Learning, IOC/Dependency Injection, Kubernetes